Beyond the Big Five



True wildlife enthusiasts know there's more to a safari beyond the tiger, lion, rhino or any other species one would expect to list. From the unique endemism of Madagascar to the winding channels of Brazil and high up in Ladakh, we take you on unique expeditions around the world.

BY SHRADDHA CHOWDHURY

What constitutes the 'Big 5' in a safari? Is it the African mix of lions, leopards, elephants, buffalos, and rhinos? Or the Indian equivalent of royal Bengal tigers, Asiatic lions, leopards, elephants, and the greater one-horned rhinos? For ardent admirers, the wildlife checklist has widened to include the rarity and elusivity of the species, limited access to unusual habitats, conservation stories, and modes of exploration like boating. These make up the new currency of a safari, where the aspect of luxury lies beyond an expensive lodge. Our guide beyond the 'Big 5' brings you wildlife experiences you simply cannot miss.

SNOW LEOPARDS IN LADAKH

Learning the behaviour of a predator that can disappear into the vast mountain landscape is no easy feat. With no guarantee of spotting the snow leopard or a simple drive to a waterhole, tracking the elusive cat is the antithesis of a traditional safari. In the interim, the Himalayan ibex, blue sheep, Tibetan wolf, red fox, and Pallas's cat may put on a show. Now, the Ladakh administration has announced India's first high-altitude wildlife safari, based around guided snow-leopard and bird-watching trails.

Recommended stay: *Snow Leopard Lodge, Ulley and Mangyu; 7-10 day safari packages starts from ₹80,000 to ₹1,50,000 per person*

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